

# Gentle parenting survival guide for physical aggression with specific scripts and boundaries — Action Checklist

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PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

## READ PRE-ESCALATION SIGNS

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- ☐ **Pre-Hit Signals:** Write down the thirty minutes before your child's last five aggressive incidents, noting time of day, location, and what happened to identify your child's specific warning pattern.
- ☐ **Track Accumulation Zones:** Watch for hunger, overstimulation, transition fatigue, and unmet needs for connection or autonomy, which are the four primary triggers that build before toddler aggression erupts.
- ☐ **Notice Stillness Before Storms:** Watch for unusual quietness or listlessness in your child, since overstimulation doesn't always look frantic and sometimes appears as a sudden shift toward stillness right before lashing out.
- ☐ **Create a Visible Pattern Card:** Document the common threads across your child's aggressive episodes and post this reference where you can see it daily to catch early warning signs before escalation occurs.

## USE SCRIPTS THAT WORK

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- ☐ **Name the Physical Feelings:** When your child is escalating, say something like "I notice your body is getting big and your hands are turning into fists" to help them recognize their internal state without shame or judgment while giving them language for what they're experiencing.
- ☐ **Offer a Safe Outlet:** Provide a specific alternative like a biting toy, pillow, or play dough the moment you see aggression building, because giving aggression somewhere safe to go prevents it from landing on you or others.
- ☐ **Repeat the Boundary Without Escalating:** Once you've stated "gentle touches only" or "teeth are for food," keep your voice calm and low as you repeat it, because toddlers need to hear limits many times before they can comply.
- ☐ **Regulate Your Own Nervous System First:** Take one slow breath before responding, because your calm presence is the only tool that can actually shift the dynamic when your child is out of control.

## REPAIR AFTER THE STORM

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- ☐ **Allow Recovery Time Before Talking:** Wait until everyone is completely calm—maybe even the next day—before briefly naming what happened, because attempting repair during residual activation makes toddlers defensive and prolongs the conflict.
  - ☐ **Forgive Yourself Immediately:** Don't rehearse apologies to your partner before leaving the room, because recognizing that you lost composure because you're human prevents shame from making your response worse the next time.
  - ☐ **Give Yourself Physical Recovery:** Take a moment alone to let your hands stop shaking and your heart rate settle, because your body needs separate repair from your child's before you can effectively reconnect with them.
  - ☐ **Set Realistic Expectations for Progress:** Understand that no script will rewire your child's developing brain, and focus on responding in ways that don't damage your relationship rather than expecting immediate behavior change.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.